PLANTS AND POETRY IN PARALLEL

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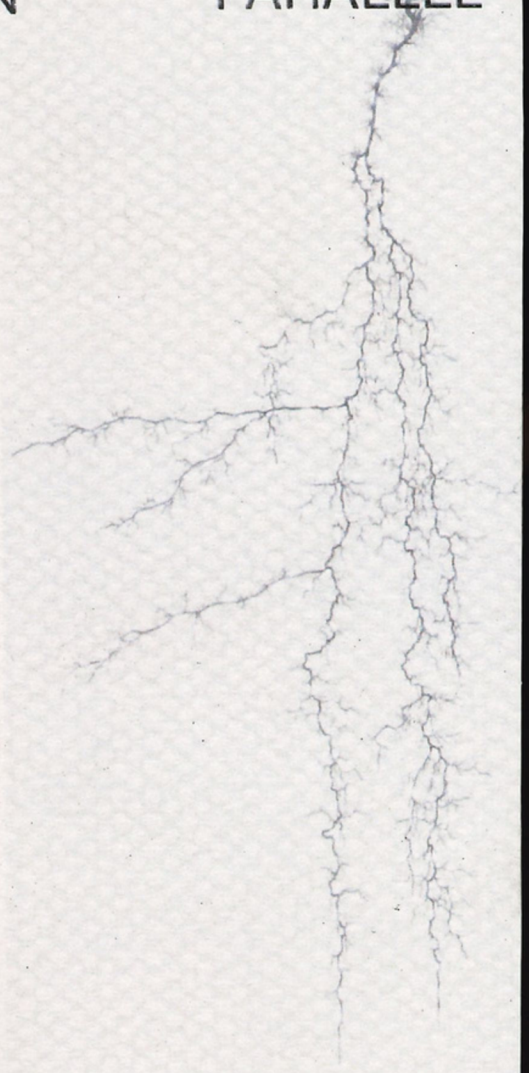
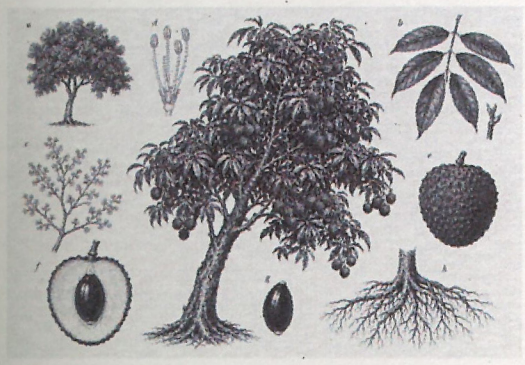


a field guide to my roots and
all
that
comes
with
it

PIA TIUTAN



LYCHEE
Litchi chinensis

name(s)	Lychee, litchi
family	Sapindacae (soapberry)
genus	Litchi
growth habit	Evergreen tree
root system	Deep vertical taproots + lateral surface roots

The lychee tree is native to Southern China, specifically provinces such as Fujian. Through trade and migration, it spread to other parts of the continent, eventually making its way to the Philippines.

My roots started growing
long before I started growing
in my mother's womb.

In 1927 (nearly a century ago),
my ancestors left Fujian
following old trade routes to Manila
so Chinese roots could grow into Filipino soil.

A passport mishap
turned Tiu
to Tiu & Tan
to eventually, Tiutan.

A surname born by accident,
we were the only ones of our kind
in the world.

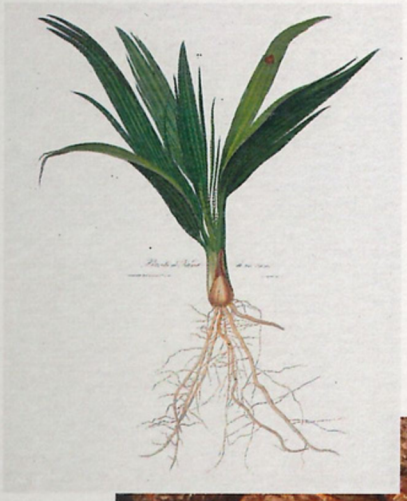
Three generations have passed,
but traces of our ancestors remain.

Red polo shirts for birthdays,
dice landing on fours for *pua tiong chiu*,
a backwards walk and three spins for *ting huns*.

Filipino *moreno* boys climbing the
"great wall of Chinese parents"
just to ask a *chinita* to be their date
for prom
or more,
if they dare.

Respect made known
by a *beso* to the cheek,
by proper titles for the elders,
by honoring gestures and traditions.

All these
take root within me,
laying the foundation for who I am today,
anchoring me to a history older than my own.

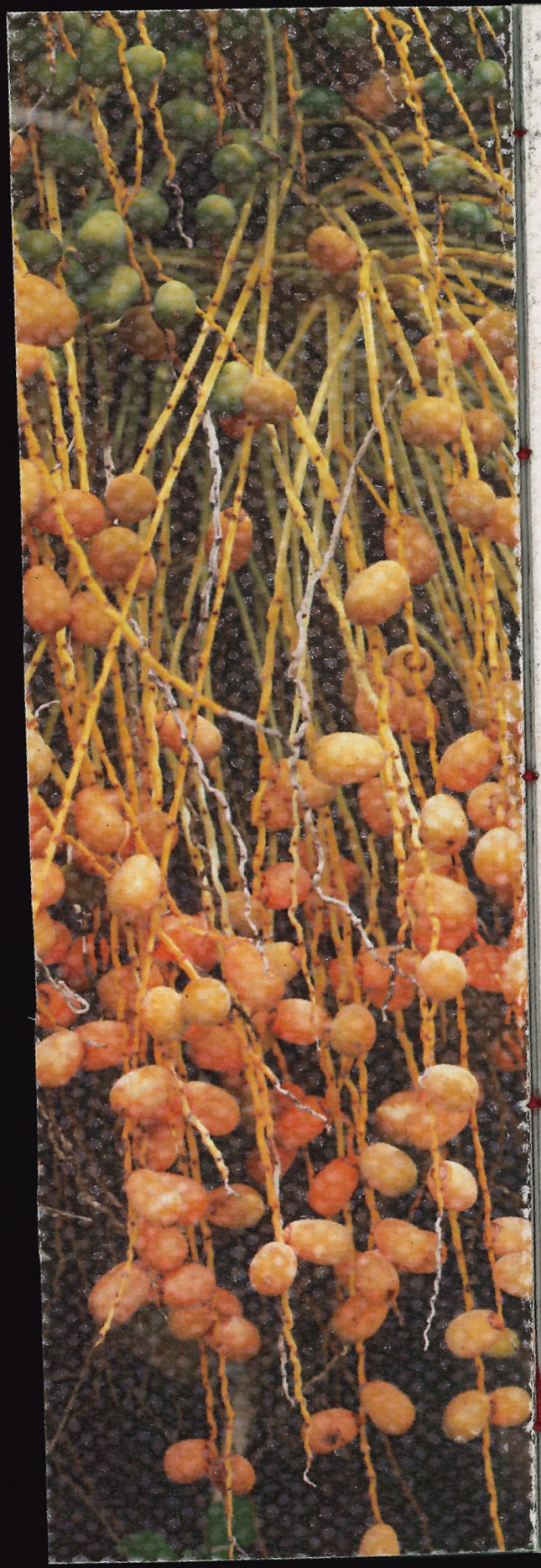


DATE PALM

Phoenix dactylifera

name(s)	Judean date palm
family	Arecaceae (palm)
genus	Phoenix
growth habit	Evergreen palm
root system	Fibrous, adventitious root system

Cultivated for thousands of years, the date palm has long held cultural and religious significance. Known for its resilience, the date palm thrives in harsh desert conditions. Frequently referenced in the biblical passages, it is associated with peace and spiritual flourishing.



Thirteen years spent
at a school run by nuns.

Skirts below the knee,
socks three inches above the ankle,
no colored undergarments that could peek through.

When the 12:00pm bell rings,
stillness fills the hallways
as the girls stop in their tracks
& bow
their
heads in s i l e n c e.

Two fingers to the forehead,
the chest,
then both shoulders,

the body followed with discipline, when
the heart didn't understand,

so I strayed away.

Yet questioning, wrestling, even demanding
still brought me back,

not to the same blind obedience. This time,
the heart that finally knows,
it was never the movements that mattered.

Frustrated by those who misuse the book
as a shield – or worse, a sword.

In the name, they say,
with judgment, hubris and contempt.

I know better now.
They do not speak for this.

My life, my choices, my values,
rooted in its words.

In the name, I strive to say,
with empathy, humility, and grace –
as He has shown us.

CORN
Zea mays

name(s)	Corn, maize
family	Poaceae (grass)
genus	Zea
growth habit	Tall graminoid (grass)
root system	Fibrous root system

BEANS
Phaseolus vulgaris

name(s)	Common bean, pole bean
family	Fabaceae (legume)
genus	Phaseolus
growth habit	Pole (climbing)
root system	Taproot with basal roots

SQUASH
Cucurbita pepo

name(s)	Squash, pumpkin, zucchini
family	Cucurbitaceae (gourd)
genus	Cucurbita
growth habit	Bush or vine
root system	Taproot + extensive lateral roots

The Three Sisters is a long-standing traditional Indigenous agricultural practice in which corn, beans, and squash grow together, each supporting the others. Corn provides structure, beans contribute to soil fertility, and squash retains moisture. Additionally, a fourth sister, the sunflower, is planted nearby to attract pollinators and provide additional protection.

On the road ahead,
one lights the path.
First to brave the winds,
first to face its wrath,
protecting all of those behind.

Trailing behind,
one keeps the pace steadily.
Steering clear of the chaos,
observing all discernfully,
a steady presence for those around.

Bouncing around,
one seeks for new adventures.
Darting from place to place,
pulling everyone along with her,
making anywhere feel like home.

I try to fit my little feet into
footprints they've left behind, following
trails they've cleared for me.

How lucky am I
to have never felt what it's like
to live a life
with no one to guide
me, support me, and fight
for me, no one to my side.

I know I've only gone as far as I have
because I never walked alone.

As I dare to hike my own mountains,
I look back gratefully
on the roads we shared.

I'm at peace knowing
if I ever lose my way,
if I ever stray too far,
if I ever need to find them,
I can always follow our roots back home.

TAMARIND

Tamarindus indica

name(s)	Tamarind
family	Fabaceae (legume)
genus	Tamarindus
growth habit	Evergreen to semi-evergreen tree
root system	Fibrous, adventitious root system

Though not native to the country, the tamarind was brought over from the Philippines to the Americas through colonial trade networks in 1567, particularly by the Manila-Acapulco Galleon Trade.

I wonder if my ancestors had known
what was to come,
would they have done the same?

A little under a century ago,
they left their home
for a better life, a hopeful future.

To the pearl of the Orient Sea –
a country once known for a booming economy
was soon afflicted by
mismanagement,
corruption,
debt,

eventually earning the (dis)honor of being called
"the Sick Man of Asia."

I wonder if my ancestors knew
that at nineteen years of age,
I would do the same.

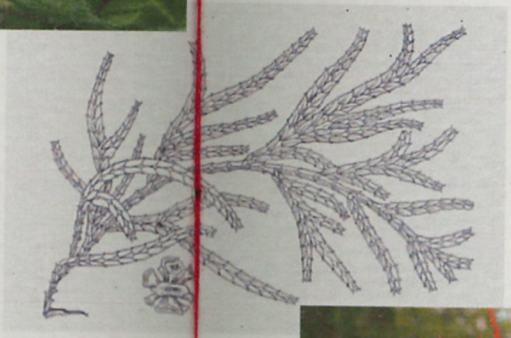
A little over a decade ago,
I left my home
for a better degree, a new adventure.

To the city of angels –
a journey once meant for education
extended for a career I couldn't find back home
turned into a lifetime with a partner,
opportunity for my children.

Nights spent cooking *sinigang* with tamarind
for a taste and a reminder of what's left behind.

It's a strange thing
to try and build a life
in a country whose leader has made it clear,
people like me aren't wanted here.

Yet, my life is taking root in this foreign land I now call
"home."

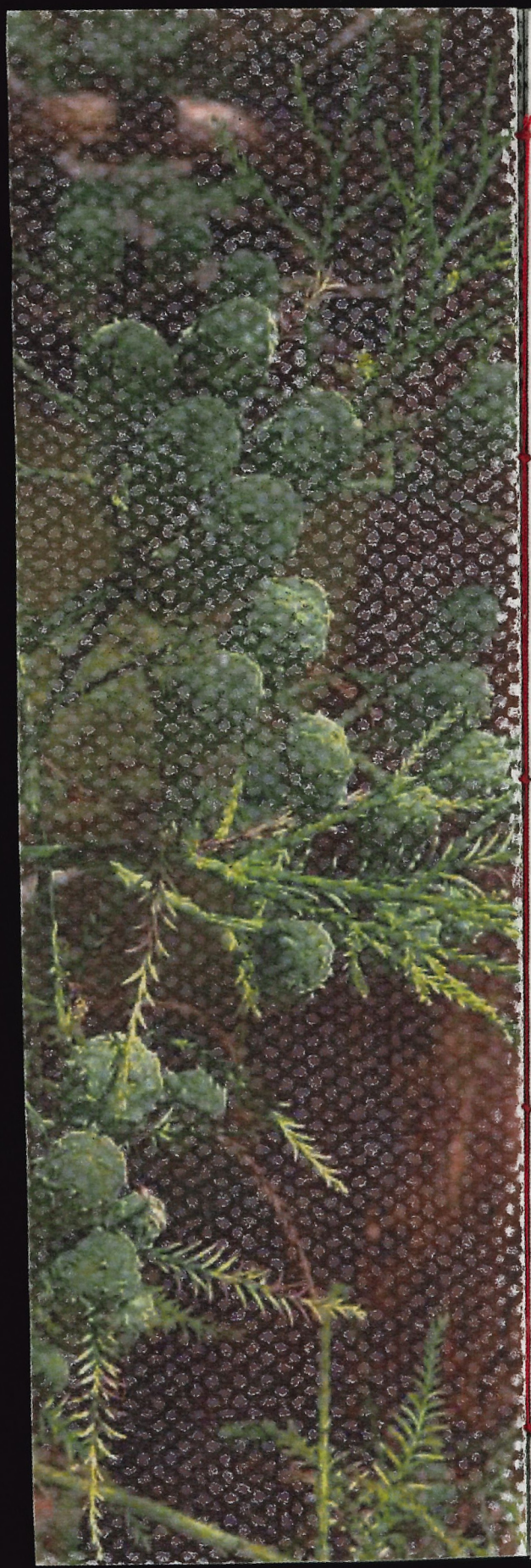


WATER PINE

Glyptostrobus pensilis

name(s)	Chinese swamp cypress, water pine
family	Cupressaceae (cypress)
genus	Glyptostrobus
growth habit	Deciduous conifer tree
root system	Shallow with aerial roots

The Chinese swamp cypress is the only living species of the *Glyptostrobus* lineage. Native to the Fujian region, the tree has been added to IUCN's list of threatened species in 2010 and is considered critically endangered.



A language endures
in the hands of its people,
but only if those people decide
it's worth keeping on their tongues.

What happens to a language when it loses its purpose?

Banned from classrooms, dismissed by nationalists,
exchanged for more valuable languages of trade -
a dialect reserved for the home.

Fluency declines with every generation
that finds less reasons to keep it around.

What happens to a language when it loses its teachers?

A language passed down by mouth
relies only on people to keep it alive.

As they scatter, one language fractures to many,
until versions across the sea
sound unrecognizable to mine.
Voices to learn from get fewer and fewer.

What happens to a language when it loses its people?

In my country, they call it
lan nang oe – our people's language.

But, as I stumble over words that feel out of reach
and incoherent sounds come out of me,
I sometimes wonder if I'm a part of "our people."

What happens to a language when it loses its life?

Linguists have warned: Hokkien's on its last legs.

I'm saddened by the feeling of inevitability
of its loss – and everything it carries with it.

But how can I grieve something
I barely even knew?
I feel guilty feeling like its death
would be one I help cause.

I hope to never attend its funeral in my lifetime,
so, I persist, scrambling to retain
what little I can keep on my tongue.

CONSIDER A TREE FOR A MOMENT. AS BEAUTIFUL AS TREES ARE TO LOOK AT, WE DON'T SEE WHAT GOES ON UNDERGROUND – AS THEY GROW ROOTS. TREES MUST DEVELOP DEEP ROOTS IN ORDER TO GROW STRONG AND PRODUCE THEIR BEAUTY. BUT WE DON'T SEE THE ROOTS. WE JUST SEE AND ENJOY THE BEAUTY. IN MUCH THE SAME WAY, WHAT GOES ON INSIDE OF US IS LIKE THE ROOTS OF A TREE.

— Joyce Meyer